

“Get there first with the most men.”

FORREST’S MOTTO FOR WINNING MILITARY VICTORIES

Hero or villain?

Like many elite Southern white men of the era, Forrest valued his reputation and sought to enhance it. In 1868, he and a journalist produced an authorized biography to shape his legacy. Instead of portraying a vicious prewar enslaver who made huge profits, the biography made him out to be a reluctant participant in enslavement who was careful not to separate family members. Bills of sale, however, are evidence that Forrest frequently sold children as individuals, away from their families. At least three formerly enslaved men would recall how their families had been torn apart at Forrest’s slave market. Before Forrest died, he allegedly said, “I hope I am a better man,” but since the mythology—that he created—persists even today, he will likely remain a polarizing figure.